Part VIII: The Millennium and the Open Horizon

Draft 1. 20,176 words.

Chapter 47: What remains open, and how long is a little season?

Part VII ended with an unresolved tension, and this Part has to work inside it rather than start the argument over.

I am carrying the previous Part's results forward at exactly the strength they were recorded, and no higher. **PF-01** — the first finding of this book, that the great eschatological transition entered history in the first century — stands at SUPPORTS: biblically plausible and increasingly supported, but not historically established. Satan's binding cannot date anything. The whole weight of dating rests on the first resurrection, which leaves fewer historical traces than anything else in this investigation. And the beast, the false prophet and Babylon are still unidentified, so the marker at the front end of the thousand years is still missing.

That changes the question. It is no longer whether a substantial first-century fulfilment can be defended. It is the harder question that follows from it:

> **If that transition really occurred, where does Revelation 20 leave the thousand years — and where, if anywhere, are we now?**

I do not know whether the second half of that question has an answer. This Part may end without a "you are here." If so,

that is a result, not a failure, and I would rather say so than manufacture a marker the evidence cannot carry.

TAKING STOCK BEFORE GOING FURTHER

Before opening new lines of investigation, I reviewed what the preceding stages had already established. That changed the shape of the remaining work. Five questions seemed to stand between Part VII and the present-day question, and earlier work had already answered substantial parts of four of them.

QUESTION	WHAT THE INVESTIGATION HAS ALREADY ESTABLISHED
What happens during the thousand years?	The nations remain on the scene throughout. The population of that period cannot be reduced to the resurrected saints alone.
What changes when Satan is released?	One specific restraint ends — the restraint on deceiving the nations — and the nations are gathered toward the final conflict.
What are Gog and Magog?	Revelation's own use of the names has been examined. Their background in Ezekiel 38–39 still needs to be brought together (Chapter 48).
What are the camp and the beloved city?	Examined earlier; the identification remains qualified where the text does not settle it (Chapter 52).
What does *war* mean in Revelation?	The range of the word across the book still needs to be gathered in one place (Chapter 52).

So two pieces of groundwork remained, not five. But the review also turned up something that was not on the list at all, and it matters more than any of them.

THE QUESTION I HAD KEPT OPEN WITHOUT EVER TESTING

Every time χίλια ἔτη (*chilia etē*, "a thousand years") has come up in this book, it has come up as a disclaimer: not established, not assumed, not included. PF-01 explicitly excludes it. Earlier chapters listed it as open.

Each of those disclaimers was correct. But when I looked back across the preceding fifty-eight stages, I found that I had repeatedly kept the thousand years open without ever directly testing what kind of duration Revelation 20 describes. I had been careful not to assume an answer — and repeated caution had begun to look like an answer when it was not one.

This question governs everything that follows. Part VII established that Satan's binding cannot date the beginning of the thousand years, because the conditions it describes fit almost any century before the final coalition. If the number cannot date the length either, then neither end of the interval can be fixed, and "are we inside it or past it?" stops being a question about the calendar. It becomes a question about conditions.

THE TEST, FIXED BEFORE THE ANSWER IS KNOWN

The question that decides it: **does Revelation ever use a number in a way that is demonstrably not literal?**

If it does, "a thousand years" cannot simply be assumed literal. If it never does, the literal reading gains real weight. There are three possible outcomes, and they lead to genuinely different investigations:

1. **Literal.** An end-point can be calculated, and history can be tested against it.
2. **Symbolic.** There is no end-point to calculate, and the question has to be answered from the conditions Revelation describes.
3. **Not determined by the text.** Revelation does not support the question in the form I have been asking it.

The third outcome would not be a failure. It would be a finding about what the text does and does not tell us.

The material for this test is already gathered: forty-two months, 1,260 days, and "a time, times, and half a time," which describe one interval three ways; the number of the beast and its manuscript variant; the 144,000; the seven heads and seven kings. Chapter 49 carries out the test. It is not decided here.

THE CALENDAR QUESTION

Before going further, there is a proposal about the calendar itself that this chapter has to address openly, because the pressure that makes it attractive arrives later in this same chapter.

Why test the calendar at all?

Revelation 20's thousand years raise two separate questions: how literally the number should be taken, and — if it is roughly literal — when the period begins and ends. If the thousand years began in the first-century transition and lasted approximately a thousand calendar years, they would have ended roughly a millennium later. But conventional chronology places about two thousand years between that first-century horizon and today. For an approximately literal reading, that is a problem.

One response is that the thousand years are not a literal measure of elapsed time. A more radical response, which some writers propose, is that conventional chronology itself is wrong — that roughly a thousand years were inserted into the historical record, so the centuries we count were never actually lived.

That is an extraordinary claim and has to be treated as one. The question is not whether Revelation proves missing centuries; it cannot, and I will not use it that way. The question

is whether independent historical and physical evidence even permits a displacement of that size.

The arithmetic, stated carefully

Two different calculations are easily confused here, and they must be kept apart.

The first is only an orientation point. Counting back a thousand years from 2026 lands at 1026. That says nothing about when the thousand years of Revelation 20 began.

The second is the hypothesis itself. Suppose a span of roughly AD 100 to 1100 never happened and was inserted into the record afterward. Then every year we now label is a thousand more than the years that actually passed:

> **THE INSERTED-MILLENNIUM HYPOTHESIS, WORKED THROUGH**
>
WHAT WE CALL THE YEAR	WHAT IT WOULD ACTUALLY BE
2026	1026
AD 70 + 1,000 years = 1070	would be labelled 2070
Remaining time	about 44 years
>
> This is arithmetically consistent, provided the entire insertion falls after AD 70. **The hypothesis is not incoherent. It is unevidenced** — a different and more precise objection.

What the hypothesis would actually do to the evidence

If the years labelled AD 100–1100 did not happen, every early manuscript of the New Testament would fall inside the disputed span: the papyri, the great codices conventionally dated from the second to the fifth century, the whole chain of copying, the formation of the canon, and every early writer and council. And the Greek text I have quoted throughout this book is a modern edition reconstructed from exactly those manuscripts.

It is important to state this precisely, because a stronger version of the objection is tempting and wrong. **The manuscripts would not disappear, and their Greek would not change.** They would still sit in their libraries and still read exactly what they read. A revised chronology redates artifacts; it does not delete them.

What would have to be rebuilt is everything around them: their dates, their origins, their order relative to one another, and the historical setting each is read against. The readings themselves would survive — the matching verb at the binding, the identical form in the Greek of Isaiah, the case mismatch at Revelation 20:4, the small phrase “any longer” at 20:3. But every judgement about which witness is earlier, what it responds to, and what it can establish would have to be made again. If verified, the hypothesis would require rebuilding the very apparatus used to verify it. That is a serious objection, and it does not need overstating.

The defence is self-sealing; the claim is not

This distinction decides whether the proposal can be tested at all.

The defence usually offered for it seals itself. Any evidence dated inside the disputed window — manuscripts, coins, inscriptions, lists of rulers, councils — can be dismissed as part of the invented span. On that way of arguing, no counter-evidence from the period can ever count, because the evidence against the hypothesis is automatically reclassified as part of the fiction. That is not an argument. A method that allows an unanswerable objection at every step is not a method, which is why I refuse it.

But the underlying claim is different. “Roughly a thousand conventional years were inserted into the record” is a claim about elapsed time, and it can be tested against any clock that does not depend on the disputed documents. Dismissing a testable claim as untestable would be its own kind of convenience — and I would be doing it to a proposal I have every motive to be rid of.

If a large block of centuries had been inserted into conventional chronology, evidence independent of medieval European historical writing should expose it. Here are the tests, written down before any of them is run, so the proposal cannot later be judged by whichever test proves most convenient:

FIVE EXTERNAL TESTS, NAMED IN ADVANCE

TEST	WHY IT APPLIES
ECLIPSE RECORDS	Eclipses can be calculated backward with great precision, and observations of them survive in traditions that never coordinated with European chronicles — Assyrian, Chinese, Greek and Roman among them. Matching an ancient record to a calculated eclipse requires a correction factor, known as delta-T, which for remote centuries is itself estimated partly from those same ancient records. That correction limits how precisely a record can be matched; it does not come anywhere near centuries. A genuine thousand-year displacement would produce discrepancies vastly larger than the uncertainties involved in matching well-attested ancient eclipses to calculation.
TREE-RING SEQUENCES	Continuous, overlapping sequences of annual tree rings, cross-matched between regions.
THE ISLAMIC CALENDAR	A continuous count of years from its own starting point in AD 622, kept by communities outside the European chronicle tradition.
OTHER CALENDAR TRADITIONS	The Ethiopian calendar, for example, numbers its years about seven to eight years behind the Gregorian; the year that began in September 2026 is 2019 in that reckoning. Calendars can count differently — but by single digits, not by a millennium. (The Hebrew calendar's year count has its own history of development, so it is a check on continuity of record-keeping rather than an independent physical clock.)
RADIOCARBON AND STRATIGRAPHY	Physical dating methods, cross-checked against the tests above.

One rule governs all of them: **Revelation may not be used as evidence for the chronology being tested.** Otherwise I would be doing exactly what I have refused throughout this book — finding an outside theory that makes the text work, then using the text to confirm the theory. Chapter 50 runs these tests.

Three supporting observations, none of which holds

The Y2K problem — the "millennium bug" — points the opposite way. It existed because computer systems stored years as two digits. The century and the millennium were never recorded at all; a two-digit counter rolls over precisely because the leading digits are missing. The fault came from the thousands digit being left out, not added. If anything, it is evidence against the connection.

The letter-shaped numeral is a fair question, but not evidence. Early modern printing and engraving often rendered the numeral one with a glyph closely resembling a capital letter. Resemblance alone establishes nothing. But there is a form of the question that can be researched: do dated objects conventionally read as from the 1600s or 1700s begin with a character that documents of the same period demonstrably treated as the numeral one? That can be answered from original dated artifacts. Appearance alone cannot answer it.

And modern signs cannot date Revelation 20. Whatever is currently being pointed to — an institution, a symbol, a detail on a monument — none of it can establish that Satan's release is near. If the biblical chronology really points somewhere, it has to stand without them. An argument that needs a current news item to hold it up was never standing.

AN ASSUMPTION I HAD NOT EXAMINED

Setting the calendar question aside entirely, something real remains, and I nearly missed it while working through the arithmetic.

I had been asking whether we are in the little season without ever establishing that the thousand years are over. I had carried that assumption from stage to stage without stating it. And it matters more than an unsettled detail, because of what Part VII established about the two possible starting points: you cannot count from a beginning you have not identified. The question of where we are now is not merely open; it depends on a prior question this investigation has not yet answered.

So three possibilities remain, and none is eliminated:

POSSIBILITY	STATUS
The thousand years are past, and the little season is underway now	Live. This was my own working assumption, and I had not recognized it as one.
The thousand years are underway now, and Satan's release is still ahead	Live — and it does not require any revision of conventional chronology.
The thousand years are entirely future	Live, and deliberately not eliminated.

The second possibility deserves a note. One can hold that the transition happened in the first century *and* that the thousand years have not yet run out, on ordinary chronology, if

the thousand years are not a literal calendar thousand — which is exactly what this Part has not yet settled.

And the third stays open for a reason that costs me something. My argument connects Yeshua's warnings in Matthew 24 to Paul's in 2 Thessalonians 2; if that connection ever fails, a wholly future thousand years has to remain available. Retiring that possibility now, because the current argument leans early, would be precisely the kind of pre-commitment this investigation exists to avoid.

WHERE DO THE SAINTS REIGN?

One line of reasoning runs like this: Messiah is at the Father's right hand; the saints are with Messiah; therefore the saints reign in heaven.

What is established does point that way. The martyrs are "under the altar" (6:9). The great multitude stands "before the throne and before the Lamb" (7:9). The overcomer is promised a seat "with Me on My throne" (3:21). But Revelation also supplies evidence in the other direction, and it is not weak.

LAND IMAGERY ON BOTH SIDES — THE LOCATION STILL UNRESOLVED

Revelation 5:10: "You have made them a kingdom and priests to our God, and they reign on the earth" — βασιλεύουσιν ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς (*basileuousin epi tēs gēs*). The tense of the verb is genuinely disputed in the manuscripts; see the note below.

Revelation 20:9: the nations "went up over the breadth of the earth" — ἐπὶ τὸ πλάτος τῆς γῆς (*epi to platos tēs gēs*) — "and surrounded the camp of the saints and the beloved city."

So there is land imagery attached both to the saints and to their reign, and it does real work: I cannot assume that the saints' existence is exclusively heavenly.

But it does not do more than that. Revelation 20:9 comes *after* Satan's release; it describes the final assault, not the thousand years. It places a camp on the earth at the end of the interval. It does not establish that the resurrected saints who reign in 20:4–6 were in that camp during the interval, or even that the two groups are the same people. Revelation's own sequence leaves room for that distinction: ordinary nations continue through the thousand years, so faithful people may be living among mortal populations while those who reign are somewhere the text does not specify.

Revelation 20:4 itself names no location for the thrones. The overcomer is given authority over the nations, who are on the earth — but a sphere of rule is not the address of a throne.

So: *the saints are with Messiah* — established. *The reign takes place only in heaven* — not established. *Only on earth* — not established either. **The location remains unresolved**, now with text on both sides rather than an absence of evidence.

A GENUINE VARIANT IN REVELATION 5:10 SOURCE-LANGUAGE

The verb in Revelation 5:10 is textually disputed, and I will not settle it here.

- **Present tense** — βασιλεύουσιν (*basileuousin*), "they reign" — is printed by the SBL Greek New Testament and by Westcott and Hort.
- **Future tense** — βασιλεύσουσιν (*basileusousin*), "they will reign" — is printed by the Nestle-Aland edition and has the support of the Byzantine tradition.

Calling either one "the Greek text" would mean choosing an edition and hiding the choice. So the verse cannot carry a present-tense argument on its own. And an English reader who meets "they shall reign" is not being given a translator's invention; they are being given one side of a real division in the manuscripts.

One more passage I will not use. Isaiah 65:20 describes someone dying at a hundred years old as a youth, and it is sometimes used to estimate lifespans during the thousand years. But Isaiah 65:20 contains death, and Revelation 21:4 says death will be no more. Treating the two passages as describing the same state produces a direct contradiction. So that verse cannot be used to calculate lifespans during the thousand years, or anyone's chances of seeing its end. Any

connection between the passages would have to be demonstrated first.

HOW LONG CAN A LITTLE SEASON BE?

Now the question that puts pressure on all of this: not *where* the little season is, but how long it can be.

Two passages in Matthew 24 bear on that question and on what might be read as signs of it: the wars, famines and earthquakes of 24:6–8, and the warning in 24:12 that "the love of many will grow cold." An earlier Part relied on the first half of 24:12 — that lawlessness would increase — without examining its second half. Chapter 51 examines both passages in full.

Short — a thousand years — short

Revelation frames the thousand years with two short periods:

- **Revelation 12:12** — the dragon knows he has ὀλίγον καιρόν (*oligon kairon*), "a short time."
- **Revelation 20:2, 4, 6, 7** — χίλια ἔτη (*chilia etē*), "a thousand years," four times in six verses.
- **Revelation 20:3** — Satan must be released μικρὸν χρόνον (*mikron chronon*), "for a little while."

The two short-time expressions are different phrases, as an earlier Part established, so John is not saying the two periods are equal. Revelation 6:11 uses the same two words as 20:3 in

reverse order — the martyrs are told to rest "a little while longer" — and Chapter 51 compares all of these expressions together.

What the wording gives and does not give:

- **No number.** Not seven years, not forty, not seventy.
- **A characterization.** The period is short — and it is called short in a passage that has just said "a thousand years" four times in six verses.

So a reading that turns the little season itself into an era on the scale of a millennium carries a real textual burden. It is not impossible, but it must be argued, not assumed.

And there is a counterweight against my own position. In my reconstruction, the "short time" of Revelation 12 already covers roughly four decades, from Messiah's victory to the first-century crisis. So "short" in Revelation demonstrably does not mean months. Decades fall well within it.

The four-way constraint

Put four things side by side.

FOUR STATEMENTS THAT CANNOT ALL BE TRUE TOGETHER

1. **PF-01 — a first-century beginning for the transition — remains at SUPPORTS.**
2. **The thousand years** (χίλια ἔτη, *chilia etē*) are approximately chronological — roughly a thousand calendar years.
3. **The little season** (μικρὸν χρόνον, *mikron chronon*, "a little while") is genuinely short.
4. **We are presently in the little season.**

A first-century start plus a chronological thousand years places the end of the thousand years around the eleventh century. That would make the present day roughly nine hundred and fifty years into a period the text calls short — a period that follows one the same text calls a thousand years. Those two words cannot both be doing their job in that sentence.

At least one of the four has to give, and the possibilities are exhaustive:

- **(a)** the beginning was not in the first century;
- **(b)** the thousand years are not a chronological measure;
- **(c)** we are not in the little season;
- **(d)** conventional chronology does not match the biblical interval;
- **(e)** some other premise, not yet identified, is wrong.

Later chapters refer to these by letter, and I will restate them each time.

This tension is exactly why the inserted-millennium hypothesis is attractive. The instinct found a genuine problem, and option (d) — conventional chronology is wrong — dissolves it cleanly.

But I set (d) aside earlier in this chapter, and the order matters. The calendar proposal was quarantined in Part VII, on two structural grounds, before I knew how much pressure the length of the little season would put on the model. Had I met the pressure first and the theory second, I could not show — to a reader or to myself — that I was not reaching for whatever made the problem go away. Neither of those structural grounds is a verdict on the claim itself, which remains testable, and Chapter 50 tests it.

So the tension is real, and the most convenient way out of it is closed for reasons that predate the tension. That is the kind of pressure an honest investigation should welcome. It is now a stated constraint on the argument rather than a feeling.

Three conditions, not one question

"Are we in the little season?" can be sharpened into three distinct conditions:

CONDITION	WHAT DISTINGUISHES IT
Late in the thousand years — Satan still bound	Sin, disaster, corrupt rulers and human deception may all be present. But the process Revelation 20 describes — nations deceived and drawn into a gathering — has not begun.
Early in the little season — Satan released	Deception and alignment are underway, but the coalition has not yet surrounded the saints.
Late in the little season — the coalition complete	The saints are surrounded, and in the narrative, intervention is imminent.

The consequence matters: something that looks like things "ramping up" may still belong to the first condition, unless the specific change Revelation 20 describes can be demonstrated.

SIGNS, AND WHAT THEY CAN AND CANNOT SHOW

The control is fixed now, before Chapter 51 examines the Matthew passages.

The birth pains, earthquakes, wars, lawlessness and cooling of love in Matthew 24 may not be lifted out and placed into Revelation 20:7 without textual justification. They belong to Matthew's own setting until an argument moves them.

And the distinction that matters most: **a phenomenon occurring is not a prophecy being fulfilled.** Modern earthquakes show that earthquakes occur. They do not show that the earthquakes of Matthew 24:7 are presently being fulfilled.

That yields a real narrowing. Revelation 20:7–10 does not list earthquakes, floods, volcanoes, famines or pestilence as the signs of Satan's release. Its markers are deception, the nations, gathering, war, the saints surrounded, and fire. So physical upheaval carries little weight as a sign of this particular period, unless another text independently supplies it.

There is one text that might. Ezekiel 38–39, where Revelation gets the names Gog and Magog, does include great phys-

ical upheaval. So the question is not whether Matthew's earthquake language transfers to Revelation 20. It is which parts of Ezekiel John carries forward and which he leaves behind. Part VII began that work, finding that John takes Ezekiel's *names* and Elijah's *fire*. Chapter 48 continues it.

WHAT THIS CHAPTER LEAVES US WITH

Most of the remaining groundwork turned out to be done already. What was genuinely missing was smaller and more important than I expected: I had never directly tested what kind of duration the thousand years are. I had set the question aside so carefully, so often, that setting it aside began to look like answering it.

Then the question of how long the little season can be put more pressure on the model than any earlier stage had. If the thousand years are calendar years and began in the first century, they ended around the eleventh — which would put us now about nine hundred and fifty years into something the text calls short.

That tension is what makes the missing-thousand-years proposal tempting. The instinct is understandable. But the proposal was set aside for reasons that have nothing to do with convenience: it would not erase the manuscripts this book quotes, but it would force everything built on their dating and order to be rebuilt, and the defence usually offered for it

shields itself from any counter-evidence. The claim itself remains testable, and it will be tested.

So the tension stands. And beneath it is the more valuable discovery: I had been asking whether we are in the little season without establishing that the thousand years are over.

The number comes first. Everything else waits on it.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. PF-01 is carried forward at **SUPPORTS**, no higher. Satan's binding cannot date anything, and the beast and Babylon are still unidentified. The thousand years have never been directly tested, and that test now comes first, with its question and three possible outcomes fixed in advance. The inserted-millennium chronology is arithmetically coherent; it would redate, not erase, the manuscripts this book reads from; its usual defence is self-sealing, but the claim itself is testable, and five external tests have been named. All three positions on the present — thousand years past, present, or future — remain open. The reign's location has land imagery on both sides and remains unresolved. And the little season, called short and given no number, creates a four-way constraint that cannot be fully satisfied, with options (a) through (e) defined above.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** Does Revelation ever use a number in a way that is demonstrably not literal? Chapter 49 answers that. First, Chapter 48 asks what John takes from Ezekiel 38–39 when he names Gog and Magog — and what he leaves behind.

Chapter 48: Ezekiel 38–39 and the Gog fingerprint

The previous chapter ended by narrowing a question. Revelation's account of Satan's release lists no earthquakes, floods or famines; its markers are deception, the nations, gathering, war, the saints surrounded, and fire. But Ezekiel 38–39, the passage from which Revelation takes the names Gog and Magog, does contain great physical upheaval.

So the question is not whether Matthew's earthquake language transfers into Revelation 20. It is narrower, and it can be answered:

> **What does John actually carry over from Ezekiel — and what does he leave behind?**

THE FIRE, TESTED AGAIN

Part VII found that the fire in Revelation 20:9 is not written in Ezekiel's words. It is written in the words of 2 Kings 1:10 — the account of fire coming down on the soldiers sent to arrest Elijah. (The Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint, groups Samuel and Kings as four books of "Kingdoms," so the same verse appears there as 4 Kingdoms 1:10.)

Instead of simply citing my earlier conclusion, I tested the comparison again from the underlying texts, without treating

the previous result as settled. It received no automatic pass, because a good deal of the argument rests on it.

THE COMPARISON, WORD BY WORD

2 Kings 1:10 (Greek): καὶ κατέβη πῦρ ἐκ τοῦ οὐρανοῦ καὶ κατέφαγεν αὐτόν — "and fire came down from heaven and consumed him."

Revelation 20:9: καὶ κατέβη πῦρ ἐκ τοῦ οὐρανοῦ καὶ κατέφαγεν αὐτούς — "and fire came down from heaven and consumed them."

Ezekiel, by contrast, has God speaking in the first person: "I will judge him… and I will rain… fire and brimstone" (38:22), and "I will send fire" (39:6).

SOURCE	"CAME DOWN"	"FIRE"	"FROM HEAVEN"	"CONSUMED"	SHARED
Ezekiel 38:22 (Greek)	no	yes	no	no	1 of 4
Ezekiel 39:6 (Greek)	no	yes	no	no	1 of 4
2 Kings 1:10 (Greek)	yes	yes	yes	yes	4 of 4

Revelation 20:9 shares four elements with the Elijah account and one with Ezekiel — and that one is "fire," πῦρ (*pyr*), the subject of the sentence in all four texts.

So the fire is the one element whose wording does *not* come from Ezekiel. It might seem the safest Ezekiel feature to carry into Revelation 20; it is the opposite. **John takes the**

names from Ezekiel and writes the sentence from the Elijah account.

A PHRASE JOHN DID NOT USE

Ezekiel 38:19 describes "a great shaking" in the land of Israel when Gog comes. In Hebrew it is רַעַשׁ גָּדוֹל (*ra'ash gadol*); in the Greek of the Septuagint, σεισμὸς μέγας (*seismos megas*), "a great earthquake." It is a fixed two-word phrase, standing in the very passage John draws on for Gog and Magog.

Revelation 20:7–10 does not use it — not the noun, not the adjective, no word for shaking at all.

That raises a fair question: does John use the phrase anywhere else? He does. σεισμὸς μέγας appears at Revelation 6:12, at the opening of the sixth seal; at 11:13, when a tenth of the city falls; and at 16:18, at the seventh bowl, where the earthquake is described as greater than any since people have been on the earth.

WHAT THE ABSENCE SHOWS, AND WHAT IT DOES NOT

John knows the phrase and uses it three times elsewhere in Revelation. In the one passage where he draws on Ezekiel's Gog account — the passage where Ezekiel itself uses the phrase — he does not.

That is a fact about the text, and it is stronger than a simple failure to import a detail. It is not, by itself, proof of John's intention. *John does not use it here* is a datum. *John deliberately withheld it* would be a reading of his purpose, and the evidence does not establish that.

Either way, the direction agrees with the previous chapter: the signs in Revelation 20:7–10 are deception, the nations, gathering, war, the saints surrounded, and fire. No shaking, no upheaval, no physical signs.

THE CONDITION OF THE PEOPLE ATTACKED

In Ezekiel 38:8 and 38:11, the people Gog attacks live לָבֶטַח (*lavetach*) — "in security," safely, with confidence. The Greek translates both occurrences as ἐπ᾽ εἰρήνης (*ep' eirēnēs*), "in peace." Not safety, not confidence — peace.

That is a genuine shift in translation: Hebrew *security* becomes Greek *peace*. Part VII raised the question of whether John's allusions to Daniel follow a particular Greek version of Daniel (the one associated with Theodotion), which makes it a live question whether he read Ezekiel in Greek as well. If he

did, his source said the people were living *in peace* when Gog came.

The rest of their condition: the invasion comes "in the latter years" (ἐπ᾽ ἐσχάτου ἐτῶν, *ep᾽ eschatou etōn*); the people live without walls, bars or gates; the invaders come "to plunder plunder and to despoil spoil"; and the people dwell "at the navel of the land" (ἐπὶ τὸν ὀμφαλὸν τῆς γῆς, *epi ton omphalon tēs gēs*). The doubled wording of the plunder clause is deliberate. Ezekiel repeats the idea for emphasis, and the Greek keeps the repetition; I have kept it in a wooden form so the construction can be seen rather than smoothed into polished English.

One limit is important. "Security" or "peace" describes the condition of the people attacked, just before the attack. It does not require that no crime, war, sickness or wickedness exists anywhere else. So no test for the thousand years may be built on the principle "if anyone suffered, it was not the millennium." No period in history could pass such a test, which means it is not a test. A settled, unwalled people worth plundering is a description of a particular people at a particular moment, not a survey of the world.

THE COALITION: NINE NAMES, AND THE SEPTUAGINT UPDATES TWO

Ezekiel 38:2–6 names nine peoples or rulers: Gog, Rosh, Meshech, Tubal, Persia, Kush, Put, Gomer and Togarmah.

THE RENAMING STARTS INSIDE THE SEPTUAGINT

The Greek translator does not simply transliterate two of these names. He renders Kush as Αἰθίοπες (*Aithiopes*, "Ethiopians") and Put as Λίβυες (*Libyes*, "Libyans") — replacing the Hebrew names with the peoples of his own day.

So the practice of mapping Gog's coalition onto contemporary geography begins in the ancient translation itself. That cuts both ways. It shows the names were treated as updatable. It also shows that every update belongs to whoever made it, not to the prophet, and is dated to that person's world.

And John goes further: he reproduces no list at all. Revelation 20:8 speaks of "the nations which are in the four corners of the earth, Gog and Magog" — the two names stand in apposition to "the nations," as another way of naming them, not as a separate roster.

What the text does not authorize

A common line of reasoning runs: *Persia is this modern state, Gog is that one, therefore Revelation predicts the following war.*

That reasoning goes beyond both John and the Septuagint. John named no one. The Septuagint renamed two peoples, for its own time. Neither of them authorizes a modern map, and this book does not draw one.

WHAT EZEKIEL'S JUDGMENT IS FOR

Ezekiel 38:20 lists eight things that tremble or fall: the fish, the birds, the wild animals, the creeping things, all people,

the mountains, the cliffs, and every wall. Ezekiel 38:22 lists six elements of judgment: pestilence, blood, flooding rain, hailstones, fire and sulphur. (Where the Hebrew has "pestilence," the Greek has "death" — a small difference in the translation, noted rather than smoothed over.)

> **THE PURPOSE FORMULA, FOUR TIMES**
>
> Four times across Ezekiel 38–39 — at 38:16, 38:23, 39:7 and 39:21–22 — the same purpose is stated, built on the Hebrew verb "to know" and rendered consistently in Greek as γνώσονται (*gnōsontai*), "they shall know."
>
> Ezekiel's judgment on Gog is not simply the destruction of an enemy. Its stated purpose, four times over, is that the nations shall know who the LORD is.

Revelation, for its part, moves directly from Gog's destruction to the throne, the judgment and the new creation.

That sets a high bar against identifying any present-day conflict with this one. A war that ends in a settlement, a new border or an exhausted stalemate is not what either text describes. The outcome both texts describe is universal recognition, and nothing less.

A PROCESS — AND NO STATED DURATION

Ezekiel describes a process, not an instant: preparation, mustering, movement, invasion, encirclement, destruction. So a little season that unfolds over time, rather than in a single moment, is consistent with the source. That is the textual

support for the three conditions set out in the previous chapter — late in the thousand years, early in the little season, late in the little season. Ezekiel's account really does have that shape.

But John gives no timetable in either direction. He does not say how long the gathering takes, or how long after Satan's release it begins. The process is Ezekiel's; the silence about its length is John's.

WORD STUDY — παρεμβολή (*PAREMBOLĒ*), "CAMP"

Revelation 20:9: the nations "surrounded the camp of the saints and the beloved city" — τὴν παρεμβολὴν τῶν ἁγίων (*tēn parembolēn tōn hagiōn*).

The word means an encampment: an army's camp, a fortified position, a body of people encamped together. In the New Testament it is used for the Roman barracks in Jerusalem (Acts 21–23), for armies (Hebrews 11:34), and for Israel's camp, "outside the camp" (Hebrews 13:11–13).

In the Greek Old Testament it occurs more than two hundred times, and it is the standard word for Israel's camp in the wilderness — the camp of Israel, with the pillar of cloud standing between it and the camp of Egypt (Exodus 14:19–20); the camp in which the people trembled at Sinai (19:16–17); the camp of the tribes arranged around the tabernacle (Numbers 2). When Jacob meets the angels of God, he calls them "the camp of God" (Genesis 32:1–2).

So the word in Revelation 20:9 carries both a concrete, spatial sense and a long association with the covenant people encamped under God's presence. What the verse places on the earth is a camp at the end of the thousand years, surrounded by the nations. As Chapter 47 showed, that does not by itself place the saints who reign in 20:4–6 in that camp during the thousand years.

The range of the word "war" (πόλεμος, *polemos*) across Revelation is gathered in Chapter 52.

DECEIVED NATIONS, AND WHAT THAT MEANS FOR THE EVIDENCE

REVELATION SAYS SATAN *DECEIVES* THEM — AND THAT HAS A CONSEQUENCE

Someone who is deceived does not, by definition, understand the source or purpose of what they are doing. So the participants in Gog and Magog need not announce anything. Their stated cause may be political, economic, territorial, moral, religious or a matter of security — and still be what John describes. No one in the account has to know they are in it.

That consequence cuts *against* easy identification, not for it. If the participants' own account of themselves cannot confirm the diagnosis, it cannot count as evidence for it either. Their stated reasons, declared aims and self-descriptions all drop out of the evidence, because the text has already said those may be beside the point.

It would have been convenient to read "they are deceived" as permission to identify any sufficiently large conflict regardless of what its participants say. It is the reverse. It removes their statements from the evidence in both directions — which makes the description harder to match, not easier.

A present-day analogy — multinational action without a single motive

Revelation 20 does not say that the deceived nations understand the ultimate purpose of their gathering. Their stated reasons for acting

> could therefore differ from John's theological account of what is actually happening.
>
> A modern institution such as the United Nations offers an illustrative analogy — not an identification. It brings many nations into a common political structure for diplomatic, humanitarian, legal and security purposes, while those nations keep their own governments, interests, disagreements and motives. United Nations peacekeeping operations, staffed by personnel contributed by member states, show how people from many nations can take part in one coordinated mission.
>
> None of this establishes that the United Nations is Gog and Magog, that Revelation predicts it, or that its emblem fulfils any prophetic image. The comparison establishes something much narrower: multinational coordination does not require every nation taking part — or every person acting within it — to understand the event in the same way or to share the same motive.
>
> The observation is interesting. The identification is not established.

WHAT THIS CHAPTER LEAVES US WITH

I tested the fire comparison a second time, from the texts, without relying on the earlier result. It came back four to one: four elements shared with the account of fire falling on Elijah's would-be captors, one shared with Ezekiel — and that one is "fire" itself, the subject of every one of these sentences. So the fire is the one thing John did not take from Ezekiel. He took the names and wrote the sentence from elsewhere.

Then something quieter. Ezekiel's Gog passage contains a great earthquake, and in Greek it is "a great shaking," two words that John uses three times elsewhere in Revelation. He does not use them here. There is no shaking anywhere in his account of the release, the gathering or the assault. That is a

real feature of the text, though it does not tell us John's intention.

And one finding changed my method rather than my conclusions: Revelation says the nations are deceived. That does mean the event could be identified without anyone in it agreeing. It also means no one in it can be quoted as evidence either way — which removes a tool at exactly the point where the coming chapters need tools.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. John carries over Ezekiel's names and very little else. The fire is written in the words of the Elijah account, by a four-to-one comparison tested again from the texts. The great earthquake of Ezekiel's Gog passage is absent from Revelation's account of the release, gathering and assault, though John uses that phrase three times elsewhere. The people attacked are settled, unwalled and worth plundering — with the Greek turning Hebrew "security" into "peace" — and that describes a particular people, not a world without suffering. The Septuagint already renamed two of the coalition's peoples for its own day; John lists no one at all. Ezekiel supplies a process with stages, which makes a developing little season textually possible, but John gives it no duration. The camp of the saints is a word long associated with Israel's camp under God's presence. And the statement that the nations are deceived removes the participants' own testimony from the evidence in both directions.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. If John gives the little season no duration, can the thousand years before it be measured at all? That depends on how Revelation uses numbers — the test Chapter 47 fixed in advance, and Chapter 49 carries out.

Chapter 49: A thousand years — what the number can and cannot tell us

Two chapters ago I found that, across the preceding fifty-eight stages, I had never directly tested what kind of duration the thousand years represent. Every earlier treatment had deliberately left the question open. I also wrote down the test before I knew which way it would go:

> **Does Revelation ever use a number in a way that is demonstrably not literal?**

The order matters. The test was written first so that it could not be adjusted once the answer arrived. What follows is the answer, and it is not the one that makes my argument easier.

EVERY NUMBER IN REVELATION

I went through every number in all twenty-two chapters of Revelation — every quantity the book attaches to something.

THE ANSWER TO THE TEST IS NO

Revelation never attaches a number to something that cannot, in principle, be counted or measured. Days, months, years and hours are measurable durations. Stadia and cubits are measurable distances. Angels, seals, churches, elders, gates, horns and heads are countable things.

The book uses nine distinct durations: ten days, half an hour, five months, one hour, forty-two months, 1,260 days, three and a half days, "a time, times, and half a time," and a thousand years.

So Revelation's numbers are consistently attached to things that can be counted — *even when those numbers carry obvious symbolic weight*. That means "a thousand years" cannot be dismissed as a figure of speech simply because a thousand is a round and resonant number.

But it is important to see exactly how far that goes, which is less far than it first appears.

A countable noun does not make its number an ordinary one. The 144,000 are people, and people can be counted. The seven heads, the ten horns and the twelve gates are all countable. Every one of those numbers is also doing symbolic work.

So this test establishes that the thousand years refer to a duration — they are not a free-floating metaphor with no time attached to them. But it does not establish that "one thousand" must be read as an exact numerical magnitude.

Symbolic numbers can still describe real, countable things, and a survey of *what* numbers are attached to cannot tell a symbolic quantity from an ordinary one. We need a second line of evidence: not merely what the number measures, but how Revelation handles numerical size.

THE NEXT TEST CHANGED THE QUESTION

Going through every number in the book, rather than only the ones near Revelation 20, turned up something a narrower search would have missed.

REVELATION 21:17 — A MEASUREMENT RELATES ITSELF TO ORDINARY HUMAN MEASURE

ἑκατὸν τεσσεράκοντα τεσσάρων πηχῶν, μέτρον ἀνθρώπου, ὅ ἐστιν ἀγγέλου (*hekaton tesserakonta tessarōn pēchōn, metron anthrōpou, ho estin angelou*) — "a hundred and forty-four cubits, by human measurement, which is also an angel's."

In a chapter describing a city coming down out of heaven, measured by an angel with a golden rod, John stops to say that the cubits are human measure.

That matters. John's vision can use recognizable units. But a recognizable unit does not by itself settle how a magnitude should be read. The 12,000 stadia of the city and the 144 cubits of its wall are genuine measurements within the vision; the remaining question is whether their size functions as architectural dimension, as symbol, or as both. Part VI already cautioned against running the New Jerusalem's measurements through plain arithmetic. Revelation 21:17 establishes the measuring convention — not, by itself, the function of every number in the book.

The same idiom appears elsewhere. Revelation 13:18 says of the beast's number: ἀριθμὸς γὰρ ἀνθρώπου ἐστίν (*arithmos gar anthrōpou estin*) — "for it is a man's number," or "a human number." Part VII left open which of those readings is right, because the Greek has no article and permits more than one. Revelation 21:17 shows John using the same construction, unambiguously, to mean ordinary human measure. That

does not settle 13:18. It does show that the "human reckoning" reading belongs to John's own vocabulary, not merely to the grammar's possibilities.

HOW JOHN REFERS TO THE THOUSAND YEARS

The phrase "a thousand years" occurs six times in six verses, and the use of the article ("*the* thousand years") is not random.

VERSE	WITHOUT THE ARTICLE — "A THOUSAND YEARS"	WITH THE ARTICLE — "*THE* THOUSAND YEARS"
20:2	Satan bound "a thousand years"	
20:3		"until *the* thousand years were completed"
20:4	they reigned with Messiah "a thousand years"	
20:5		"until *the* thousand years were completed"
20:6	they will reign with Him "a thousand years"	
20:7		"when *the* thousand years are completed"

The firm part of this pattern is the right-hand column. All three times the thousand years are referred back to as a completed whole, the phrase carries the article, and all three use the same verb in the same form (τελεσθῇ, *telesthē*, "should be

completed”). Two of these clauses begin with “until” and one with “when.”

The left-hand column is less certain. In the SBL Greek text, the three introducing verses have no article; but at 20:4 and 20:6 some manuscripts and editions read “the thousand years,” so the contrast in those verses depends on the edition.

Even so, the completion clauses show how John treats the period: as something with a definite end that can be “completed.” That is how a writer handles a definite, bounded period, not an indefinite “long while.”

A CAUTION APPLIED TO MY OWN BEST MATERIAL

Revelation gives forty-two months twice, 1,260 days twice, and “a time, times, and half a time” once. Forty-two times thirty is 1,260; the arithmetic is real. Many interpreters equate the two figures by assuming a thirty-day month, but Revelation itself never states the equation — not in one verse, not anywhere. It uses both.

So the equivalence is suggestive, not demonstrative. It would be easy to say “Revelation converts between units” and treat that as proof of a precise chronological habit. Revelation does not convert. It uses both figures, and the difference between those two statements is the difference between evidence and a flattering summary of evidence.

Two further cautions apply, in opposite directions.

Symbolic significance does not cancel quantity. Twelve carries enormous symbolic weight in Scripture, and there really were twelve apostles. The inference "this number means something, so it counts nothing" is invalid.

And six repetitions do not establish 365,000 days. Revelation supplies no calendar, no convention for counting the first and last year, and no rule for rounding.

What is firmly established is that the period is *bounded*: a definite interval, with a beginning, an end, and clauses saying it reaches completion. Where its length falls between "an indefinite age" and "exactly one thousand solar years," the text does not say — and I am not entitled to place it on that scale because a placement would be useful to the argument later.

PSALM 90:4 AND 2 PETER 3:8

Any discussion of the thousand years soon reaches Psalm 90:4, and it deserves a careful look.

WORD STUDY — "A THOUSAND YEARS" OUTSIDE REVELATION

Psalm 90:4, Hebrew: כִּי אֶלֶף שָׁנִים בְּעֵינֶיךָ כְּיוֹם אֶתְמוֹל כִּי יַעֲבֹר וְאַשְׁמוּרָה בַּלָּיְלָה

In Greek: ὅτι χίλια ἔτη ἐν ὀφθαλμοῖς σου ὡς ἡ ἡμέρα ἡ ἐχθὲς ἥτις διῆλθεν, καὶ φυλακὴ ἐν νυκτί

"For a thousand years in Your sight are like yesterday when it is past, and like a watch in the night."

The verse compares a thousand years to *two different things*: to yesterday, and to a watch in the night. Yesterday is a day; a night watch is a few hours. Read as a conversion formula, the verse would produce two different rates in one sentence. That is not a formula failing. It is a text that was never doing arithmetic — and a few verses later the same psalm asks God to "teach us to number our days." A psalm asking for help with counting is not supplying a conversion table.

2 Peter 3:8 confirms this from the other side: μία ἡμέρα παρὰ κυρίῳ ὡς χίλια ἔτη καὶ χίλια ἔτη ὡς ἡμέρα μία — "with the Lord one day is *as* a thousand years, and a thousand years *as* one day." The word "as" (ὡς, *hōs*) appears in both halves. As arithmetic, the statement runs both ways at once and cancels itself. It is a comparison, made twice, not an equation.

Peter's own point is about patience, not measurement: the Lord is not slow about His promise, as some count slowness, but patient, not wanting any to perish but all to come to repentance (3:9).

Two more observations about 2 Peter 3.

First, the scoffers Peter answers ask, "Where is the promise of His coming?" — and the word for "coming" is παρουσία (*parousia*), the same word that carries Paul's argument about the Lord's coming examined in Part VII. Here it

appears in a first-century complaint that the *parousia* had not yet arrived. I note it and build nothing on it; it belongs to a question this Part is not asking.

Second, it is sometimes suggested that the Lord's patience in 2 Peter 3:9 means waiting for particular people, not yet born, who must first be born and repent. Peter does tie God's patience to repentance. He does not say that the delay exists so that specific future people can be born. That may be a reasonable theological extension, but it is an inference from the text, not something the text states.

THE VERDICT

WHAT THE EVIDENCE ESTABLISHES ABOUT THE THOUSAND YEARS

The thousand years (χίλια ἔτη, *chilia etē*) **designate a definite, bounded interval, stated in the language of quantity:** SUPPORTS.

The evidence for this: the completion clauses, which refer back to "*the* thousand years" and say they are completed; the contrast that the thousand years are numbered six times while the release that follows is not numbered at all; the fact that every number in Revelation attaches to something countable, so this is not a figure of speech attached to nothing; and the principle that symbolic weight does not by itself cancel quantity.

Whether that quantity is meant as approximately one thousand ordinary years is not established: PERMITS, reaching no higher than a weak SUPPORTS.

Why it stops there: the survey of numbers cannot separate symbolic quantity from ordinary quantity, since the 144,000, the seven heads, the ten horns and the twelve gates are all countable and all symbolic; Revelation 21:17 establishes what a cubit is, not how to read every number in the book; no calendar, counting convention or rounding rule is given anywhere; and Part VI already declined to apply plain arithmetic to the New Jerusalem's own measurements.

Not established at all: exactly one thousand solar years; that any particular year is year one; that John equates forty-two months with 1,260 days.

Part VII anticipated a difficult consequence, and it now arrives.

THE TENSION, STATED CONDITIONALLY

PF-01 — a first-century beginning for the transition — stands at SUPPORTS. **The thousand years are a bounded interval described in the language of quantity** — also at SUPPORTS.

Those two together do not yet produce a date. The difficulty arises only with a third claim, the one just graded no higher than PERMITS: that the length is approximately a thousand ordinary years.

So the tension is conditional, and stating it conditionally is the whole point. *If* the thousand years are approximately chronological, *then* a first-century beginning places their end around the eleventh century. That leaves roughly nine hundred and fifty years between that end and the present — a period Revelation 20:3 would be calling μικρὸν χρόνον (*mikron chronon*, "a little while"), immediately after a period the same passage calls χίλια ἔτη (*chilia etē*, "a thousand years"). The contrast would no longer be long against short. It would be a thousand years against nine hundred and fifty.

The condition matters in both directions. It is why the calendar test in the next chapter matters at all. And it is why that arithmetic is not forced by the text: the reading that creates the whole tension is the weakest-graded claim in the argument, not the strongest.

There is also a cost to notice. Part of the case for reading the thousand years as a real quantity was the contrast John draws: he numbers the thousand years six times and only *characterizes* the release as short. If the short period were

> nine hundred and fifty years, that contrast would disappear. The argument that made the number matter is the same argument that now says we cannot be standing where I had assumed.

WHERE THE FIVE OPTIONS STAND

Chapter 47 identified five possibilities, at least one of which must be true if the four statements of the four-way constraint cannot all hold together. Here is where they stand now:

OPTION	WHAT IT SAYS	STATUS
(a)	The transition did not begin in the first century.	Live — but this is PF-01, at SUPPORTS.
(b)	The thousand years are not a chronological measure.	Weakened, not closed. Their boundedness is at SUPPORTS; their approximate length is no higher than PERMITS, so this option remains genuinely live.
(c)	We are not presently in the little season.	Under the least pressure of the five.
(d)	Conventional chronology does not match the biblical interval.	Set aside in Part VII, before this tension was known; tested in Chapter 50.
(e)	Some other premise, not yet identified, is wrong.	Live, and by definition cannot be examined until it is identified.

Option (c) is now the one under the least pressure, in a specific sense: no established finding stands against it. Option

(a) would overturn PF-01; option (b) must set aside the evidence that the thousand years are bounded; but "we are presently in the little season" was an assumption carried forward, never a finding, so denying it costs nothing the investigation has established. Less pressure against an option is not evidence for it, and no option is selected here. Two of the five have moved, both because of evidence gathered for other reasons, and that is as far as this chapter can go. An argument that picks its escape route at the moment of greatest pressure has not been tested; it has been rescued.

WHAT THIS CHAPTER LEAVES US WITH

The test was fixed in advance: does Revelation ever put a number on something that cannot be counted? Going through all twenty-two chapters, the answer is no. Days, months, years, hours, stadia, cubits, angels, gates, horns — every number in Revelation is attached to something that can in principle be counted.

Then something I did not expect. Near the end of the book an angel measures the city with a golden rod, John gives the wall as 144 cubits, and he pauses to say that this is human measurement. A city coming down from heaven, measured by an angel, and the writer stops to tell us the cubits are ordinary ones. That shows John's numbers can use real units. It does not show how to read the size of every number, and it does not tell me how to read "a thousand."

So the conclusion is narrower than it first seemed. The thousand years are a bounded period, described in the language of quantity. Whether that quantity is anywhere near a thousand ordinary years, the book does not say, and I have graded it accordingly.

Even the conditional version runs against what I was hoping to find. A first-century start plus a thousand years ends in the eleventh century, and from there to now is about nine hundred and fifty years. The text sets a thousand years against a little while. Nine hundred and fifty years is not a little while beside a thousand; it is nearly the same again.

I should also be clear about what that means. Escaping the difficulty does not require some clever argument I would have to invent. It requires only declining the weakest-graded claim in my own chain: that the thousand years are approximately a thousand calendar years.

The investigation had not needed to assign the number a definite value until this point. Once the question was asked directly, with the test written down first, the tension acquired a number of its own.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Revelation never attaches a number to something uncountable, which rules out reading the thousand years as a figure of speech attached to nothing — but the survey cannot separate a symbolic quantity from an ordinary one. John relates the city's measurement to ordinary human measure, which settles the measuring convention, not how to read every magnitude. The completion clauses treat the thousand years as a definite period that reaches its end: **SUPPORTS**. That the period is approximately a thousand ordinary years: **PERMITS**. The equivalence of forty-two months and 1,260 days is an interpreters' calculation, not John's statement, and the verses usually offered as a "day equals a thousand years" formula turn out to be comparisons, not equations. The result is a conditional tension: *if* the thousand years are approximately chronological, nine hundred and fifty years now stand between their end and the present, which Revelation would be calling a little while. Of the five options, (c) — we are not presently in the little season — is under the least pressure. None has been selected.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. Option (d) would remove the tension at a stroke: if conventional chronology is wrong by about a thousand years, the arithmetic changes completely. Chapter 50 runs the external tests named in Chapter 47 to see whether that is possible.

Chapter 50: The chronology under test

The previous chapter ended with a sum I did not want — a conditional one, and the condition matters. *If* the thousand years are approximately chronological, then a first-century beginning places their end near the eleventh century, leaving roughly nine hundred and fifty years between that end and the present. Revelation would be calling those nine hundred and fifty years "a little while," immediately after a period it calls "a thousand years."

There is an obvious way out — option (d) of the five set out in Chapter 47: conventional chronology does not match the biblical interval. If about a thousand years of the conventional record never happened, the sum works. The end of the thousand years moves forward, the little season becomes genuinely short, and everything fits.

I have kept that possibility set aside since Part VII. This is the chapter where it is tested rather than simply refused. And I want to say plainly, before any of it, that I would have been glad if it held. It would have solved the arithmetic.

It does not hold. And the way it fails is part of why I think the rest of this book can be trusted.

THE RULES, SET BEFORE LOOKING

Before any historical evidence was examined, the biblical side of the argument was fixed — at the end of the previous chapter. That was not a courtesy. It is the condition under which looking at history at all is legitimate.

The standards for the historical test had been set much earlier still, long before there was any model to test.

> **THE STANDARDS FOR THE HISTORICAL TEST**
>
> **The order of operations.** First the Bible, and a textual model built from it independently; only then historical evidence, as an independent test. Never the reverse: an interesting historical theory, followed by a search of Scripture for verses that resemble it.
>
> **The governing rule.** A hypothesis being compatible with Scripture is not evidence that it happened. *Could fit*, *does fit* and *proves* are three different categories, and they are never merged.
>
> **Five categories for the verdict.** What fits; what does not; what is silent; what contradicts; and what requires special pleading. The point of the scheme is to prevent browsing through history until something looks like the millennium.
>
> **The expected outcome, named in advance.** *"Does external history corroborate, contradict, or remain neutral toward the model? All three are real answers. Neutral is the most likely, and it is not a disappointment."*

Those standards were written before any biblical model existed to test against them. A research design that anticipates its own most likely outcome is the only kind that can accept that outcome when it comes.

THE FIVE CATEGORIES, FILLED IN

The historical descriptions below are broad characterizations of the period around the eleventh century, where an approximately literal thousand years beginning in the first century would end. They are orientation, not claims established from primary sources in this book.

CATEGORY	WHAT THE PERIOD SHOWS
Fits	Large-scale transformation: political consolidation, centralized institutions, growth in population, agriculture and trade. The period also shows that ideological causes could mobilize people across regions. That is a condition that would *enable* the gathering Revelation describes — not the gathering itself.
Does not fit	The decisive element of Revelation 20's description is hostility converging on Yah's saints. The period runs the opposite way: more overt institutional Christianization, expanding monastic movements, rulers claiming Christian legitimacy, continued missionary activity. This is real counter-evidence.
Silent	Nothing in the historical record can speak to the one marker that now carries the whole weight of dating — a change in the condition of the faithful dead (the first resurrection). History is not merely unhelpful here; it is the wrong kind of evidence.
Contradicts	The arithmetic — and that is not a historical problem. It is a textual one, generated by my own two findings.
Special pleading	Redefining "the saints" narrowly enough to make the period fit. Refused, because otherwise the model becomes infinitely adjustable. Likewise, describing any long stretch of history as "increasing mobilization" — nearly any long stretch can be described that way.

The verdict, in the terms set in advance: neutral, with one contradiction that is textual rather than historical.

The counter-evidence in the second row matters regardless of who would prefer otherwise. The description in Revelation 20 requires hostility converging on God's people, and this period shows the opposite trend. A test in which counter-evidence counts only when it comes from the other side is not a test.

THE CRUSADES AND SIMILAR COINCIDENCES

Two well-known eleventh-century events, one of them the beginning of the Crusades, fall close to where an approximately literal thousand years would end. But closeness in date is the weakest of the three categories: *could fit*, not *does fit*, and nowhere near *proves*.

And the crusading reading fails on its own participants. The crusading armies understood themselves as waging Christian warfare. That does not match "nations deceived into surrounding Yah's saints" — if anything, it claims the opposite role.

Chapter 48 makes this harder, not easier. Because Revelation says the nations are deceived, the participants' own understanding cannot confirm the identification — but by the same logic, it cannot count against it either. I cannot cite the

crusaders' self-description against the identification, and I could not have cited it in favour of one.

The right question, then, is not "was this period the millennium?" It is "what conditions does Revelation 20 lead us to expect, and do surviving records show them?" That is the question the five categories ask.

THE EXIT ITSELF

The tension from the previous chapter rests on two graded findings and one permitted reading: the first-century beginning at **SUPPORTS**, the boundedness of the thousand years at **SUPPORTS**, and the reading of them as approximately a thousand ordinary years at no more than **PERMITS**. None of the three came from any theory about chronology. The tension is only as strong as the weakest of them, and I keep that in view while the proposal is tested. Because Revelation has not been used as evidence for the chronology under test, the proposal may now be examined.

When it was set aside in Part VII, it was set aside on two grounds.

The first was that the usual *defence* of the proposal is self-sealing: any evidence from the disputed period can be dismissed as part of the invention. That ground no longer blocks a test, because external tests were named in advance (Chapter 47), before any of them was run.

The second was what the proposal would do to the evidence this book reads from. Every early manuscript of the New Testament falls inside the span it declares fictional, and the Greek text I have quoted throughout is reconstructed from them. **The manuscripts would not disappear — a revised chronology redates artifacts.** But their dates, origins, order and historical settings would all have to be reconstructed, and with them every judgement about which witness is earlier and what each can establish.

So the proposal may be *tested*. It could not simply be *adopted* while that second problem stood, because the problem is about the foundations of the evidence, not about any single result. Keep that in mind for the end of this chapter.

Which proposals are actually on the table

Two published proposals revise conventional chronology, and they should not be confused.

TWO REVISIONIST CHRONOLOGIES

The Phantom Time Hypothesis. Proposed by the German writer Heribert Illig in the 1990s, it holds that roughly 297 years conventionally dated AD 614 to 911 were added to the historical record and never actually happened. It is a claim about about three centuries in the early Middle Ages — not about a thousand years after the first century.

The New Chronology. Associated with the Russian mathematician Anatoly Fomenko, it proposes a far more sweeping reconstruction, compressing and rearranging most of ancient and medieval history. It is a different kind of claim from an inserted block of years, by a different author, and it was examined earlier in this investigation alongside its mainstream assessment.

Neither one, as published, is the claim the arithmetic here requires: about a thousand years inserted after the first century, and only then.

That reframes the question rather than answering it. The theory that would have solved the arithmetic asks for a thousand inserted years. The best-known published proposal of an inserted span — Illig's — proposes 297, less than a third of what the model would need.

What the sources show

The case for the proposal came with real citations, and each was checked. Some held; some could not be confirmed as stated.

CLAIM	RESULT
A continuous tree-ring chronology of 7,272 years	Identified: J. R. Pilcher, M. G. L. Baillie, B. Schmidt and B. Becker, "A 7,272-year tree-ring chronology for western Europe," *Nature* 312 (1984): 150–52. I cite it for its published scope; its detailed data are not examined in this book.
A tree-ring sequence spanning 160 BC to AD 1129	Not confirmed at those dates, and not used here. Other published sequences covering most of the disputed span exist, at different dates.
Illig's proposal: about 297 years, AD 614–911	Confirmed.
The Gregorian calendar reform referred back to the equinox at the Council of Nicaea	Confirmed, with one discrepancy noted below.
Eight appearances of Halley's comet at roughly 76-year intervals, AD 530–1066	Six of the eight located in independent records; the 530 sighting was not located, and the 989 sighting rests on a weak mention.
The Islamic calendar counts continuously from AD 622	Confirmed; the formal numbering of its years began within a few years of its starting point.
The Hebrew calendar keeps a continuous count of years	Confirmed as a count. Its era reckoning has its own history of development, so it corroborates rather than independently decides.

The verdict below does not rest on the uncertain items. It rests on a test anyone can check.

The decisive test: the Islamic calendar

The Islamic calendar counts its years "AH" — *anno Hegirae*, "in the year of the Hijra" — from Muhammad's migration from Mecca to Medina in AD 622. Its years are lunar: a year of twelve lunar months lasts about 354.4 days, roughly eleven days shorter than a solar year. So the Islamic count gains on the solar count by about three years every century.

THE HIJRI COUNT, COMPUTED

	YEARS
Solar years from AD 622 to 2026	1,404
The same span expressed in lunar years	1,447.1 AH
The actual current Islamic year	about 1448 AH
DIFFERENCE	**ABOUT 0.9 YEARS, ACROSS FOURTEEN CENTURIES**
If a thousand of those solar years never happened, only 404 would have passed — giving	about 416 AH
YEARS THE ISLAMIC COUNT WOULD HAVE TO BE WRONG BY	**ABOUT 1,032**

A continuous count kept by a different civilization, on a different calendar, in a different unit, lands within a year of where conventional chronology places it. The inserted-millennium proposal would require that count to be wrong by more than a thousand years.

This needs no specialist apparatus: a lunar–solar conversion and two published dates, which a reader can check in a few minutes.

What the test is not is independent of every institution, and I will not claim that. It depends on the correlation of its starting point being transmitted correctly and on the count being kept faithfully for fourteen centuries. Its force is that the tradition keeping it is a *different* one, with no stake in European chronology — independence of interest, not independence from all human record-keeping.

The other tests

Chapter 47 named five external tests before any of them was run, so that the proposal could not later be judged by whichever proved convenient.

TEST	RESULT
Astronomical records	Run using recorded appearances of Halley's comet rather than eclipses: six of eight located across independently recording traditions, consistent with conventional dates.
Tree-ring sequences	A continuous published chronology of 7,272 years exists (Pilcher and others, 1984); its data are not examined here. One asserted span could not be confirmed. Supporting, not decisive.
The Islamic calendar	Run, and decisive.
Other calendar traditions	Consistent. The Hebrew count agrees with conventional chronology; the Ethiopian calendar differs from the Gregorian by seven to eight years, not by centuries.

TEST	RESULT
Radiocarbon and stratigraphy	Reported in the material examined, not tested here.

The ten days of the Gregorian reform

One detail is worth correcting. When the Gregorian calendar was introduced in 1582, ten days were dropped. The reform took its reference point from the date of the spring equinox in the fourth century, at the time of the Council of Nicaea, and ten days is the drift that had accumulated between then and 1582. That fits conventional chronology. The figure of *thirteen* days sometimes set beside it is something else: the present-day gap between the Julian and Gregorian calendars, which has grown since 1582. The argument from the reform stands, but the two figures measure different things and should not be compared directly.

THE VERDICT

> **AN INSERTED THOUSAND YEARS: CONTRADICTS**
>
> The proposal that about a thousand years were inserted into conventional chronology after the first century is contradicted by the evidence — the strongest negative grade on this book's scale.
>
> The decisive evidence is the Islamic calendar, which lands within one year across fourteen centuries and would have to be wrong by about 1,032 years. It is supported by six of eight recorded appearances of Halley's comet across separate traditions, by published tree-ring chronologies spanning the period, and by other calendar traditions that differ from the Gregorian only by single digits. And the best-known published proposal of an inserted span is less than a third of the size the model would need.

The second ground for setting this proposal aside — that adopting it would require reconstructing the dating of every manuscript this book reads from — never had to be used. The proposal failed first, on a lunar calendar supported by comet records and tree rings: evidence that has nothing to do with manuscripts.

That matters. Had the case come down to "I refuse this because accepting it would undermine my sources," a reader would be entitled to wonder whether I was protecting my method rather than following it. Instead the answer came from a calendar kept by a different tradition, with no stake in European chronology.

The rule cuts both ways, as it must. Rejecting a historical proposal does not make anything else biblical evidence. It

removes one of the five options. It confirms none of the other four.

One further possibility should be addressed: that the little season has already run its full course. Revelation places Satan's final destruction and the great white throne judgment directly after Gog and Magog, so that possibility would require those events to be past as well — and neither has been established. It is not adopted here.

WHERE THE FIVE OPTIONS STAND NOW

OPTION	WHAT IT SAYS	STATUS
(a)	The transition did not begin in the first century.	Live — but this is PF-01, at SUPPORTS, and it stands unless materially contradicted.
(b)	The thousand years are not a chronological measure.	Weakened, not closed: boundedness at SUPPORTS, approximate length only at PERMITS.
(c)	We are not presently in the little season.	Under the least pressure, and now more so.
(d)	Conventional chronology does not match the biblical interval.	CONTRADICTS — eliminated.
(e)	Some other premise, not yet identified, is wrong.	Live, and not yet examined.

Four options remain. And the one just eliminated was the only one that removed the tension cleanly, so the pressure is now higher, not lower.

That may sound contradictory: the tension rises, yet option (c) is under *less* pressure than before. The two statements measure different things. The tension is the strain on the whole set of four statements from Chapter 47. "Pressure" on an option means how much established evidence stands against it. Option (a) would overturn PF-01, which stands at **SUPPORTS**. Option (b) has to set aside the evidence that the thousand years are a bounded quantity. Option (d) has now been contradicted. Option (c) — we are not presently in the little season — has no established finding against it. Chapter 47 showed that "we are in the little season" was an assumption I had carried without testing, and nothing since has established it. Eliminating (d) adds to that, because (d) was the only option that let a roughly chronological thousand years and a present little season both stand. With it gone, anyone holding a first-century beginning and a roughly chronological thousand years can no longer also hold that we are in the little season now.

Two cautions belong with this. Less pressure against an option is not evidence for it. And option (c) says only where we are *not*; it does not say where we are. It fits two very different situations: the thousand years still underway, which requires that they are not a calendar thousand, or the little season already completed, a possibility discussed below and not adopted.

THE OPTION WITH NO ADVOCATE

Option (a) threatens the first-century beginning that much of this book defends. Option (b) has just been graded against. Option (c) is uncomfortable. Option (d) was exciting, and is now eliminated.

Option (e) — some premise not yet identified is wrong — is merely humbling, and it is easy to neglect for that reason. Eliminating (d) has made it more important, not less. So I am writing the question down where I cannot lose it: *what premise am I not examining because I do not want it to be wrong?* I do not yet have an answer.

WHAT THIS CHAPTER LEAVES US WITH

The standard for the historical test had been set long before there was a model to test: history may corroborate, contradict or stay neutral; all three are real answers; neutral is the most likely, and it is not a disappointment.

Neutral is what came back.

There is plenty happening in the period. It even shows that religious causes could move armies across borders, which is the kind of mechanism Revelation's gathering would need. But Revelation's description requires hostility converging on God's people, and the period runs the other way.

The one thing that contradicts my argument is not in the history at all. It is the arithmetic — a thousand years, followed by nine hundred and fifty more called short — and I

produced it myself, from two findings I was pleased with and one reading I could only permit.

Then the exit. The case for it came with citations, and some of them could not be confirmed as stated. If the rejection had depended on those, it would have depended on very little. It did not. What settles the matter is a calendar: the Islamic count runs continuously from AD 622, is now in its 1448th year, and is off by less than a year from what fourteen centuries of solar time predict. If a thousand years had been slipped into the record after the first century, that count would have to be wrong by more than a thousand years, kept wrongly for centuries by people with no reason to coordinate with Europe's chroniclers.

And the best-known proposal of inserted years asks for 297, not a thousand.

So the exit is closed — and the pressure that sent me looking for it is higher than before. That is not a comfortable place to end a chapter. I think it is the honest one.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. The historical test ran under standards set long before there was a model, which named neutral as the likeliest result — and neutral is what came back, with the period running against the decisive element of Revelation 20's description. The only real contradiction is the textual arithmetic, which is of my own making. The proposal that would have removed it — about a thousand years inserted into conventional chronology — was tested against five external checks named in advance. Some of the citations offered for it could not be confirmed as stated, but the verdict does not rest on them: the Islamic calendar lands within a year across fourteen centuries, supported by Halley's comet records and tree-ring chronologies, and the best-known published proposal of inserted years is less than a third of the required size. The proposal is graded **CONTRADICTS**, and the structural objection held in reserve never had to be used. Four options remain; the one eliminated was the only clean solution; and option (e) is now more important than before.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** With the calendar exit closed, one more way out remains to be examined: if the saints reign in heaven, perhaps the thousand years are measured by a different clock. Chapter 51 asks whether that works — and compares every "little while" in Revelation.

Chapter 51: What clock — and the two little whiles

The previous chapter closed the only way out that would have removed the arithmetic problem cleanly, and left the pressure higher than before. A thousand years, followed by roughly nine hundred and fifty more, and Revelation would be calling the second period "a little while" — a sum that holds *if* the thousand years are approximately chronological, which is the one link in it graded no higher than **PERMITS**.

There is a second way out, and it is more respectable than the first. If the saints reign in heaven, perhaps their reign runs on a different clock from ours, and the objection disappears without touching a single date.

I would like that to work. It does not, and this chapter says why at the outset, because leaving it unresolved would let everything after it read as special pleading. Then the chapter turns to something I was not looking for: a comparison of every "little while" in Revelation.

LOCATION IS NOT DURATION

Paul's promise that "we shall always be with the Lord" (1 Thessalonians 4:17) establishes permanent companionship with Messiah. It does not establish a place. The location of

the reign remains open, as Chapter 47 found. But even if the reign is in heaven, that does not change how the thousand years relate to our history.

> **THE BINDING CONCERNS THE NATIONS, SO THE THOUSAND YEARS RUN THROUGH ORDINARY HISTORY**
>
> Whatever else is disputed in Revelation 20, the restraint on Satan is defined by its object: he is bound so that he may no longer deceive τὰ ἔθνη (*ta ethnē*), "the nations."
>
> The nations are ordinary historical actors — the same peoples who appear throughout Revelation buying and selling, waging war, being ruled and being healed. A restraint that applies to them applies within ordinary historical time, for as long as it lasts.
>
> So the reading in which the saints reign in heaven survives intact — but it does not remove the arithmetic problem. Wherever the thrones are, the thousand years overlap the same history the nations live in. Where the saints reign and how long the period lasts are different questions, and answering the first does not answer the second.

This does not settle how long the thousand years are, or whether they must be exactly a thousand calendar years; that remains the question Chapter 49 graded. It settles only that a heavenly location cannot lift the period out of our timeline.

A second point follows from the same verse. For Satan to be released and deceive the nations at the end, the nations must

still be there. So ordinary human history continues through the thousand years: whatever else is happening, the human story is still running when the release comes.

EVERY "LITTLE WHILE" IN REVELATION

One comparison had been noted long before but not yet carried out: every place Revelation uses its words for "time" (χρόνος, *chronos*, and καιρός, *kairos*) and for "little" or "brief" (μικρός, *mikros*, and ὀλίγος, *oligos*) needed to be examined together.

WORD STUDY — THE "LITTLE WHILE" PASSAGES

Revelation describes four periods as brief:

VERSE	THE GREEK	WORDS USED	SAID OF
6:11	ἔτι χρόνον μικρόν	*chronos* + *mikros*	the martyrs under the altar, told to rest a little while longer
12:12	ὀλίγον καιρὸν ἔχει	*kairos* + *oligos*	the devil, thrown down, "knowing he has a short time"
17:10	ὀλίγον αὐτὸν δεῖ μεῖναι	*oligos* alone	the seventh king, who "must remain a little while"
20:3	μικρὸν χρόνον	*chronos* + *mikros*	Satan, released after the thousand years

Revelation 6:11 and 20:3 use the same noun and the same adjective, in reverse order. They are the only two places in Revelation where *mikros* describes a length of time. (Elsewhere it means "small" — "small and great," "a little power.")

Revelation 12:12, which is usually grouped with 6:11 as the "short time" before the thousand years, uses a different noun and a different adjective. So does 17:10, in a different way.

For completeness: *chronos* also occurs at 2:21 ("I gave her time to repent") and 10:6 ("there will be no more delay"); *kairos* at 1:3, 11:18, 12:14 and 22:10, of an appointed or approaching time; and *oligos* at 2:14 and 3:4, of "a few" things and people.

What the match shows — and how far it goes

This finding cuts in my favour, which is exactly when to slow down.

The argument of this book already places Revelation 6:11 near the beginning of the thousand years: the martyrs are

told to rest *until* their number is complete, and in 20:4 the souls of those beheaded live and reign. So 6:11 stands near one end of the thousand years and 20:3 at the other — and Revelation uses the same words for "a little while" at both.

> **THE OBJECTION IS WEAKENED, NOT ANSWERED**
>
> The objection I have pressed hardest is that nine hundred and fifty years cannot be called "a little while." That objection is weaker than I have been stating it, because Revelation uses the same expression for a second period — the martyrs' waiting — and I have never measured that period either.
>
> But this establishes nothing about the length of either one. Neither 6:11 nor 20:3 gives a duration. One unmeasured period cannot set the scale of another.
>
> So the finding is exactly this, and no more: the objection is weakened, not answered. The pressure from the previous chapter is reduced, not removed. Any later sentence in this book that treats this as a solution would be wrong.

There is also a limit on the match itself. The phrase for "a little while" is shared; the language around it is not:

VERSE	CONJUNCTION	VERB
6:11	ἕως (*heōs*, "until")	πληρωθῶσιν (*plērōthōsin*, "are filled up")
20:3, 20:5	ἄχρι (*achri*, "until")	τελεσθῇ (*telesthē*, "is completed")

VERSE	CONJUNCTION	VERB
20:7	ὅταν (*hotan*, "when")	τελεσθῇ (*telesthē*, "is completed")

Three different conjunctions and two different verbs. The phrase matches; the surrounding wording does not. That limits how much weight the match can carry.

TWO BATTLES, TWO GATHERINGS: REVELATION 19 AND REVELATION 20

Revelation describes a gathering for battle more than once, and it matters which descriptions belong together. Revelation 16:14 speaks of spirits going out to gather the kings of the earth "for the battle"; 19:19 describes the beast and the kings gathered to make war against the rider on the white horse; and 20:8 describes Satan gathering the nations "for the battle" after the thousand years.

An earlier stage of this investigation examined which of these belong together, and its result was a genuine split, not a settled answer:

WHICH GATHERING BELONGS WITH WHICH BATTLE

THE EVIDENCE	POINTS TOWARD
16:14 and 20:8 use word-for-word identical wording: συναγαγεῖν αὐτοὺς εἰς τὸν πόλεμον, “to gather them for the battle.”	Chapter 20
19:19 uses a different verb form and preposition.	Not chapter 19
In 16:13 the dragon, the beast and the false prophet are all active; in 20:10 two of them have already been disposed of.	Chapter 19

Whether chapter 16 belongs with 19, with 20, or with neither, remains open.

It is tempting to treat that open question as settled, folding all three passages into a single “complex of events before the thousand years.” It is not settled, and treating a contextually favoured reading as established is exactly the kind of upgrade this book tries to avoid.

Some things are established. The birds summoned to the “great supper” belong to 19:17–21; Revelation 20 contains no bird vocabulary at all. The word *Armageddon* (Ἁρμαγεδών) occurs only once in the whole book, at 16:16, and appears in neither chapter 19 nor chapter 20. And the earlier stage settled its own tie on sound narrative grounds: the same figure cannot be both active and already permanently disposed of in the same scene.

THE WORD "ALREADY" IN REVELATION 20:10

Revelation 20:10 is often rendered "the devil… was thrown into the lake of fire and sulphur, where the beast and the false prophet [already] are." The bracketed word deserves a closer look.

THE WORD IS NOT THERE — AND NEITHER IS A VERB TO CARRY IT

Revelation 20:10 reads: …ὅπου καὶ τὸ θηρίον καὶ ὁ ψευδοπροφήτης… (*hopou kai to thērion kai ho pseudoprophētēs*) — "where also the beast and the false prophet…"

The Greek word for "already," ἤδη (*ēdē*), is absent. And the clause has no main verb at all; it is elliptical — "where also the beast and the false prophet," with "are" understood. So a bracketed "[already]" is doubly an addition: it supplies a word that is not there, and a tense the clause does not state.

The sequential inference may well be sound: 19:20 puts the beast and the false prophet in the lake, and 20:10 finds them there. But that is an inference from the order of the narrative, not something the text says — and the bracket is exactly where the two get merged.

One detail from 19:20 is worth keeping: ζῶντες ἐβλήθησαν οἱ δύο (*zōntes eblēthēsan hoi dyo*) — "the two were thrown in *alive*."

THE HORSES, AND WHY THE IMAGERY CANNOT DATE THE BATTLE

The battle of Revelation 19 has horses in it. Does that date the scene to an age of cavalry?

The word "horse" (ἵππος, *hippos*) occurs sixteen times in Revelation, and in chapter 19 the horses are on both sides of the

same scene. The rider called Faithful and True comes on a white horse (19:11); the armies of heaven follow him on white horses (19:14); the beast's forces are described with horses and riders (19:18), and the closing verses refer back to "the one who sat on the horse" (19:19, 21).

The presence of horses in Revelation 19 does not, by itself, establish the historical period of the battle. Because the scene includes both heavenly and earthly participants, its imagery has to be interpreted in context rather than used as an independent chronological marker.

One structural detail: the last occurrence of the word is at 19:21. Horses do not appear anywhere from chapter 20 onward. What that marks is a question for another place.

A GRADE DOES NOT MOVE BECAUSE IT BECAME UNCOMFORTABLE

At this point it is tempting to say that the symbolic reading of the thousand years has become stronger. It has not.

Chapter 49 graded the chronological reading on three specific findings: Revelation 21:17's "human measurement," the way John refers back to "*the* thousand years" in the completion clauses, and the contrast between the numbered thousand years and the unnumbered release. None of those three has been answered. If the grade is to move, it must move on evidence against them, and that route is entirely open. But discomfort is not evidence. A rule against rescuing a hypo-

thesis applies on every page, including the page where keeping it costs something.

A LEGITIMATE ALTERNATIVE — AND WHAT IT COSTS

There is a serious way the thousand years could begin later without touching any chronology, and it deserves to be stated at full strength.

The weakest link in this book's chain is the connection between the crisis Yeshua describes in Matthew 24 and the crisis Paul describes in 2 Thessalonians 2. It is recorded as *PROBABLE*, not certain. If that link breaks, the beginning of the thousand years moves later on its own — no missing centuries, no redefinition, no rescue. That is option (a) from Chapter 47: the transition did not begin in the first century.

But giving up that link would cost something real. The correspondence between the two passages is dense: lawlessness (ἀνομία, *anomia*) in both; the crisis drawn from Daniel; deceptive signs and wonders; the context of the Lord's coming (παρουσία, *parousia*); and the same family of words for the gathering of His people. That much shared material cannot be set aside lightly. Option (a) remains live, and it should be weighed at that cost rather than either dismissed or adopted casually.

EARTHQUAKES, THUNDER AND LIGHTNING IN REVELATION

Revelation mentions earthquakes several times, and it is easy either to treat them all as one event or to assume they must be separate ones. The text supports neither assumption on its own.

The noun for earthquake, σεισμός (*seismos*), occurs at these points:

VERSE	THE GREEK	"GREAT"?	SETTING	WHAT ACCOMPANIES IT
6:12	σεισμὸς μέγας ἐγένετο	yes	sixth seal	the sun black, the moon like blood, stars falling (and in 6:13 the related verb: a fig tree "shaken" by wind)
8:5	σεισμός	no	before the trumpets	thunders, voices, lightnings
11:13	ἐγένετο σεισμὸς μέγας	yes	after the two witnesses rise	a tenth of the city falls; seven thousand killed
11:19	σεισμὸς καὶ χάλαζα μεγάλη	(the hail is great)	seventh trumpet; the temple opened	lightnings, voices, thunders, great hail
16:18	σεισμὸς ἐγένετο μέγας	yes, and unprecedented	seventh bowl	lightnings, voices, thunders — and in 16:21, great hail

At 16:18 the text itself marks the earthquake as without precedent:

> οἷος οὐκ ἐγένετο ἀφ' οὗ ἄνθρωποι ἐγένοντο ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς τηλικοῦτος σεισμὸς οὕτω μέγας
>
> "such as had not occurred since people came to be on the earth, so great an earthquake, so mighty."

That superlative is supplied by the text, not imposed on it.

These earthquakes come with different accompaniments and in different settings, so they cannot simply be assumed to describe one earthquake. But different wording does not, by itself, prove they are separate events either. Revelation's visions can return to the same reality from different vantage points.

What the survey does show is a recurring pattern. Lightnings, voices and thunders come from the throne at 4:5. At 8:5 the same three appear with an earthquake. At 11:19 they appear with an earthquake and great hail. At 16:18–21 they appear with the greatest earthquake in human history and great hail falling in enormous stones. The same elements return, each time with more added.

That is what this book has meant by calling Revelation's structure a *spiral* rather than a straight line: the visions do not simply proceed from one event to the next; they circle back to the same themes with increasing intensity. Here the spiral can be seen in the vocabulary itself. It shows literary

escalation. It does not establish whether 8:5, 11:19 and 16:18 describe one event or several, and I leave that question open.

WARS AND RUMOURS OF WARS: WHAT YESHUA SAID

In Matthew 24:6, Yeshua tells His disciples:

> μελλήσετε δὲ ἀκούειν πολέμους καὶ ἀκοὰς πολέμων· ὁρᾶτε, μὴ θροεῖσθε· δεῖ γὰρ γενέσθαι, ἀλλ' οὔπω ἐστὶν τὸ τέλος.
>
> "You will hear of wars and reports of wars. See that you are not alarmed, for this must take place, but the end is not yet."

The distinction matters. Wars are part of what Yeshua describes, but He does not present war as evidence that the end has arrived. On the contrary, He says plainly that it has not.

The verses that follow widen the picture. Nation will rise against nation and kingdom against kingdom, and there will be famines and earthquakes in various places (24:7) — the word for earthquakes is the same *seismos* found in Revelation, though whether that link means anything is a separate question. "All these," Yeshua says, "are the beginning of birth pains" (24:8, πάντα δὲ ταῦτα ἀρχὴ ὠδίνων, *panta de tauta archē ōdinōn*); the word for birth pains occurs nowhere else in Matthew. Then His followers will be handed over, and they will be hated "by all the nations" (24:9).

So warfare cannot, on its own, establish the timing of the events described in Revelation. Any proposed connection has to be weighed against the wider prophetic context, including the sequence and the specific conditions Yeshua names.

The survey of the word "war" itself (πόλεμος, *polemos*) across Revelation is set out in Chapter 52.

WHEN LOVE GROWS COLD: MATTHEW 24:12

An earlier Part of this book relied on the first half of Matthew 24:12 — that lawlessness will increase — and connected it to Paul's "man of lawlessness." The second half of the verse had not been examined.

> **WORD STUDY — ψυγήσεται (*PSYGĒSETAI*), "WILL GROW COLD"**
>
> Matthew 24:12: καὶ διὰ τὸ πληθυνθῆναι τὴν ἀνομίαν ψυγήσεται ἡ ἀγάπη τῶν πολλῶν — "and because lawlessness will be multiplied, the love of many will grow cold."
>
> The verb comes from ψύχω (*psychō*), "to cool, to grow cold." Its subject is "the love" (ἡ ἀγάπη, *hē agapē*), and "of the many" (τῶν πολλῶν, *tōn pollōn*) has the article — not "many people" in general, but "the many."
>
> This verb occurs only here in the New Testament. It does not appear in Revelation.

This book has built a correspondence between Matthew and Revelation across many chapters: on lawlessness, on signs and wonders, on the gathering of God's people. The cooling

of love has no counterpart in Revelation's vocabulary. That does not rule out a thematic relationship — Revelation knows about faithfulness failing (the church at Ephesus has "left its first love," 2:4). But such a relationship would have to be shown from context, not from a shared word. The correspondence is real where it has been measured, and it does not extend where it has not.

(Reference works classify the grammatical voice of ψυγήσεται differently; the meaning, "will grow cold," is not in question, and I do not attempt to settle the classification.)

WHAT THIS CHAPTER LEAVES US WITH

I came into this chapter hoping for the second way out. If the saints reign in heaven, perhaps the clock is not ours, and nine hundred and fifty years stop being a problem.

It does not work, because of one word. Satan is bound from deceiving *the nations*, and the nations are the ordinary peoples who buy and sell and go to war. A restraint on them runs through ordinary time for as long as it lasts. The thrones may be wherever the evidence eventually places them; the thousand years still overlap the same centuries I live in. Where the saints reign and how long the reign lasts are two different questions, and I had been hoping the first would answer the second. It does not — though it also does not settle how long the period is.

Then the comparison of every "little while" in Revelation returned something I had not expected. Only two places in the book call a span of time "little" with these exact words: the martyrs under the altar, told to rest a little while longer until the rest of their number is complete (6:11), and Satan, released after the thousand years for a little while (20:3). The passage usually grouped with the first, 12:12, uses different words for both halves.

The objection I have been pressing is that nine hundred and fifty years cannot be "a little while." Perhaps not. But John used the same words for another period, and I have never asked how long that one was. That does not make nine hundred and fifty years short. It means I was measuring one unmeasured thing against another and calling the result impossible. The objection is weaker than I have been stating it. It is not gone, and if this book ever treats this as a solution, the reader should hold me to this paragraph.

Revelation's earthquakes, thunders and lightnings show the spiral the book has been describing: the same elements returning, each time with more added. And Matthew 24:6 says plainly what many readers of prophecy have passed over: wars must come, "but the end is not yet." Matthew 24:12's cooling of love, meanwhile, has no echo in Revelation's vocabulary — a reminder that the correspondence between the two books has limits.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. The saints may reign in heaven, but the binding is defined over the nations, so the thousand years overlap ordinary history wherever the thrones are; the location question does not settle the length. Revelation 6:11 and 20:3 use the same two words for "a little while," and they are the only places the book uses that adjective of time; 12:12 and 17:10 describe brief periods in other words. That weakens the objection that nine hundred and fifty years cannot be "a little while," without answering it, because neither verse gives a length. Which gathering belongs with which battle remains genuinely open. The word "already" is absent from Revelation 20:10. The horses of chapter 19 are on both sides of the scene and cannot date it. The chronological reading's grade has not moved, because nothing has answered the evidence for it. Option (a) remains live at a real cost. The earthquakes show a recurring, escalating pattern without showing whether they are one event or several. Matthew 24:6 says wars are not the end. And the cooling of love in Matthew 24:12 has no counterpart in Revelation.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. Everything in Revelation 20's final scene turns on who is surrounded: "the camp of the saints and the beloved city." Chapter 52 asks how Revelation itself defines the saints — and what the word "war" means when it is waged against them.

Chapter 52: Who are the saints?

Revelation 20:9 describes the nations gathering against "the camp of the saints and the beloved city." To understand that confrontation, we first have to know whom Revelation identifies as *the saints*.

I have been using the word for eight chapters without defining it, and the question matters. Satan is released; the nations are deceived; they gather, advance, and surround the camp of the saints. That is the description this whole Part has been working toward — and it is useless if "the saints" can mean whoever I need it to mean. Chapter 50 refused to redefine the word to make a historical period fit. That refusal only has force if the definition comes from Revelation rather than from me.

So: whom has Revelation already taught its readers to recognize as the saints?

A COUNTING QUESTION, NOT A DEFINING ONE

The way the question is asked matters. The tempting version is: here is what the saints must be; now let us see whether Revelation agrees. That version produces agreement every time.

The better version is to find every place Revelation itself describes the saints, note what it says about them in each place, and then ask whether those descriptions converge on one recognizable set of characteristics or scatter across several. If they scatter, there is no usable description, and I should say so. If they converge, the convergence was not put there by me.

Much of the surrounding context is already settled: who is alive during and after the thousand years (Chapters 47 and 51), and the open question of where the saints reign (Chapter 47). So the question here is narrower than it may look.

REVELATION 12:17: THE CLEAREST IDENTIFICATION IN THE BOOK

After the dragon is thrown down, he goes off to make war on the rest of the woman's offspring — and John does not leave them unnamed.

REVELATION 12:17 — IDENTIFIED BY TWO CHARACTERISTICS

τῶν τηρούντων τὰς ἐντολὰς τοῦ θεοῦ καὶ ἐχόντων τὴν μαρτυρίαν Ἰησοῦ

"those who keep the commandments of God and hold the testimony of Yeshua."

Two elements, joined: covenant faithfulness toward Yah, and Yeshua.

Note what the verse does not say. It does not identify the dragon's target as people who identify culturally as Christians. It does not identify them as ethnic Israelites. It identifies them by what they keep and what they hold.

REVELATION 14:12: THE SAME DESCRIPTION, IN ANOTHER PART OF THE BOOK

Immediately after the passage about the beast and its mark, John writes, "Here is the endurance of the saints" — and then tells us who they are.

REVELATION 14:12 — THE SAME TWO ELEMENTS, AND HERE THEY ARE CALLED "THE SAINTS"

οἱ τηροῦντες τὰς ἐντολὰς τοῦ θεοῦ καὶ τὴν πίστιν Ἰησοῦ

"those who keep the commandments of God and the faith of Yeshua."

The same twofold description appears twice, in two different sections of the book — and here John explicitly calls these people the saints (ἅγιοι, *hagioi*).

The phrase πίστιν Ἰησοῦ (*pistin Iēsou*) carries a genuine grammatical question: it can mean "faith in Yeshua" or "the faithfulness of Yeshua." I do not settle it here, and the identification does not depend on it, because either reading keeps Yeshua inside the definition.

Add the setting both passages share — endurance under pressure — and the description is complete: Yah's commandments, Yeshua, and holding fast under force. That is about as strong an internal definition as a book can give of its own term.

WHAT THAT RULES OUT — IN BOTH DIRECTIONS

> **A DEFINITION THAT REFUSES TWO OPPOSITE SUBSTITUTIONS**
>
> It is not institutional or cultural Christianity. A body that calls itself Christian does not automatically fit a description built on keeping Yah's commandments and holding the testimony of Yeshua under pressure.
>
> It is not ethnic descent apart from Yeshua either. Both of Revelation's statements include the testimony or faith of Yeshua. That element is not optional.
>
> And Israel is not erased by saying so. Revelation is saturated with Israel: the twelve tribes, the 144,000, Moses, the temple, Jerusalem, Zion, covenant language, twelve apostles, and the names of the twelve tribes on the gates of the New Jerusalem. This is not a Gentile religion detached from Israel. It fits the covenant chain this book has traced since Part I: Israel, Messiah, the faithful remnant, and the Gentiles grafted in — not Israel discarded and replaced by something unrelated.

So for any attempt to match Revelation 20 to history, neither of two common reflexes works. "An attack on the Jewish people today is automatically Gog and Magog" is insufficient. "An attack on institutional Christianity is automatically Gog and Magog" is insufficient too. The diagnosis needs Revelation's own category, which is narrower than either and cuts across both.

WHAT "WAR AGAINST THE SAINTS" MEANS IN REVELATION

Revelation 20 has the nations gathering "for the battle" against the saints. Does that require the saints to be a population with armies, territory and a front line? Revelation's own use of the word "war" answers part of that question.

The noun πόλεμος (*polemos*), "war, battle," occurs nine times in Revelation, and it is used in four distinct ways:

HOW IT IS USED	WHERE
In a comparison — the locusts look like horses prepared for battle, and sound like chariots rushing into battle	9:7, 9:9
War against God's people — carried out by persecution, conquest and killing	11:7 (the beast makes war on the two witnesses and kills them); 12:17 (the dragon makes war on those who keep God's commandments); 13:7 (the beast makes war on the saints and overcomes them)
Conflict in heaven	12:7 (Michael and his angels against the dragon)
A gathering for the final battle — in almost identical wording	16:14; 19:19; 20:8

Every time Revelation speaks of war waged *against God's people*, it describes persecution, not two armies meeting in a field. In chapter 13 the instruments of that war are listed around the verse: pressure to worship, delegated authority, economic exclusion, marking and allegiance, and death for

refusal. In this book's own usage, then, war against the saints can be an organized assault carried out through political, religious, economic and lethal coercion at once.

Revelation 20:8–9 combines two of these patterns: it uses the wording of a gathering for battle, and its target is the camp of the saints. The word alone therefore cannot decide what kind of confrontation 20:9 describes. The earlier passages show that war against God's people need not involve two conventional armies; they do not by themselves determine the nature of that final confrontation.

A MANUSCRIPT NOTE ON REVELATION 13:7

The clause "it was given to it to make war on the saints and to overcome them" is missing from some important witnesses: the earliest papyrus of this passage (P47, third century), Codices Alexandrinus, Ephraemi and Porphyrianus, part of the Byzantine tradition, and the Sahidic Coptic version. It is present in Codex Sinaiticus, most Byzantine manuscripts, the Latin Vulgate, the Syriac, and the Bohairic Coptic version, and modern critical editions such as the SBL Greek New Testament print it.

Textual scholars commonly judge the omission to be accidental: two neighbouring clauses both begin "and it was given to it," and a copyist's eye could easily pass from the first to the second. That is a scholarly judgment about probability, not something the manuscripts themselves show, and the clause's originality has been rated as carrying some degree of doubt. The point above does not rest on this verse alone: 11:7 and 12:17 describe war against God's people in the same terms.

THE MARK CANNOT CROSS THE THOUSAND YEARS

Here this chapter takes something away from the interpretation many readers bring with them.

> ### THE BUYING-AND-SELLING RESTRICTION BELONGS BEFORE THE THOUSAND YEARS
>
> Revelation 13 describes the restriction on buying and selling. That belongs to the beast and the false prophet. And the sequence this book has traced runs:
>
> the beast and the false prophet judged → Satan bound → the thousand years → Satan released → Gog and Magog.
>
> So "no one can buy or sell" cannot be carried across the thousand years into Revelation 20. It sits on the far side of an interval the text itself places between them. And Revelation never mentions a microchip. Whatever the mark ultimately signifies, that identification is a modern overlay on the text, not a reading of it.
>
> The description of what follows Satan's release is this, and only this: deception, the nations, gathering, war, and the saints — the camp and the beloved city surrounded. Not "a new payment technology has appeared, therefore Gog and Magog."

That one argument from sequence removes a great deal of modern prophetic speculation — and it does so on the order of the text, not on taste. I am not saying the popular reading is foolish. I am saying the text puts a thousand years between the two things it joins.

The verb in 20:3 and 20:8 confirms the point. The binding is not described as general helplessness; it has a specific purpose: ἵνα μὴ πλανήσῃ ἔτι τὰ ἔθνη (*hina mē planēsē eti ta ethnē*), "so that he would no longer deceive the nations." And the release reverses exactly that: ἐξελεύσεται πλανῆσαι τὰ ἔθνη (*exeleusetai planēsai ta ethnē*), "he will come out to deceive the nations." The same verb is negated at the binding and carried out at the release, so the thousand years are bounded at both ends by the same activity. That is why the final movement begins with deception rather than anything else. And it is a second reason the conclusion of Chapter 51 holds: a restraint defined by its effect on the nations runs wherever the nations are.

MARTYRS ARE PROMINENT, BUT THE CATEGORY IS LARGER

Revelation constantly associates the saints with blood: the slain under the altar, those who "did not love their lives even unto death," war against the saints, Babylon drunk with their blood, and the beheaded who live and reign.

But "saint" does not mean "someone already killed." Revelation 14:12 — "here is the endurance of the saints" — is addressed to the living, still under pressure, not to those already through it. So the category is Yah's covenant-faithful people identified with Yeshua, whether or not they are finally martyred.

THE CAMP AND THE CITY

THE CAMP IS CORPORATE, AND "SURROUNDED" HAS TO MEAN SOMETHING

Revelation 20:9 does not say the nations persecuted some saints. It says they "went up over the breadth of the earth and surrounded the camp of the saints and the beloved city."

As Chapter 48 showed, the word for "camp" (παρεμβολή, *parembolē*) is the standard Greek Old Testament word for Israel's encampment under God's presence. That points to something corporately identifiable — not isolated individuals with no communal relation to one another.

I keep the instinct that "surrounded" should actually mean something; it should not be turned into a metaphor merely because I cannot presently identify the event. But neither can I require a literal circle of troops around a single point on a map. The image can carry geographical, political, military and covenantal dimensions at once: Yah's covenant community under comprehensive hostile encirclement.

THE BELOVED CITY — DELIBERATELY LEFT OPEN

Jerusalem and Zion are the obvious resonance, and the weight of the book's imagery points that way. But Revelation culminates in the New Jerusalem, and the apostolic writings speak of a heavenly and covenantal Jerusalem alongside the geographical one.

So I cannot prove that Revelation 20:9 means armies physically surrounding present-day Jerusalem. And I cannot prove that the beloved city has no geographical dimension at all.

The strongest formulation I can defend: "the camp of the saints and the beloved city" represents Yah's covenant people, centred in the imagery of Zion and Jerusalem, with the exact geographical dimension unresolved.

That is enough for this book. Speculative proposals about the city's location remain possible subjects of inquiry, but nothing in Revelation 20 establishes any of them, so they stay among the open questions and outside the chain of evidence.

WHERE THE IDENTIFICATION STOPS

> **THE DESCRIPTION CAN BE DEFINED. THE PEOPLE CANNOT BE POINTED TO.**
>
> - A denomination calling itself Christian does not automatically qualify.
> - A Torah-observant movement does not automatically qualify.
> - A Messianic congregation does not automatically qualify.
> - Ethnic Israel does not automatically exhaust the category.
> - Using the name does not by itself establish covenant faithfulness.
>
> Revelation's description concerns people marked by faithfulness to Yah, the testimony and faith of Yeshua, and endurance under pressure to abandon that allegiance. Yah knows His own. That is enough for this investigation, and going further would be the special pleading this book refused when it would have been convenient.

COULD IT ALREADY BE DEVELOPING?

Textually, yes — as a possibility. And the two prophetic sequences agree on its shape:

EZEKIEL'S SEQUENCE	REVELATION'S SEQUENCE
preparation	release
gathering and mustering	deception
movement	gathering
attack	advance
God's intervention	surrounding, then fire

Satan's release does not require the camp to be surrounded the same afternoon. There can reasonably be development

between the release and the final confrontation, which preserves the possibility that an early stage of the little season could already be underway. Possibility is all it is. As Chapter 49 showed, the claim that we are presently in the little season remains the one under the most arithmetic pressure, and nothing here relieves that pressure.

> **THE NEGATIVE RESULT THIS PART HAS BEEN WALKING TOWARD**
>
> A credible identification of Gog and Magog in history after the thousand years would need something closely resembling this sequence: nations deceived → broad mobilization → converging hostility → against an identifiable, covenant-faithful people belonging to Yeshua → encirclement → direct intervention by Yah.
>
> **That sequence has not been established in present history.**
>
> This is an important negative finding, and it is the point at which conviction has to stop. Not "it has not happened" — I cannot establish that either. "It has not been established." Those are different claims, and collapsing them is how every attempt at setting dates has been produced.

THE CHAIN IS COMPLETE

THE GROWING CHAIN — CHECKPOINT 6

Yeshua's first-century prophetic horizon → the apostolic mission and expectation of judgment in the first century → a first-century eschatological transition, strongly favoured → the beast and the false prophet judged, ending the war complex before the thousand years → Satan restrained → the first resurrection; the saints reigning with Messiah → the thousand years, their length still partly unresolved → Satan released for μικρὸν χρόνον (*mikron chronon*, "a little while") → the nations deceived → Gog and Magog mobilized → war against Yah's Yeshua-faithful covenant people → the camp and the beloved city surrounded → Yah intervenes → Satan finally destroyed → the great white throne → Death and Hades destroyed → new creation.

The chain is complete. The marker on it is not.

The "you are here" marker cannot presently be placed on the lower part of this chain with sufficient confidence — and nothing after this chapter should manufacture one.

WHAT THIS CHAPTER LEAVES US WITH

I have been saying "the saints" for eight chapters, and the description of Revelation 20 is useless unless John defined them before I needed them.

He did — twice, in two different parts of the book, with the same two elements both times. Revelation 12:17: those who keep the commandments of God and hold the testimony of Yeshua. Revelation 14:12: those who keep the commandments of God and the faith of Yeshua. Add the endurance both passages describe, and the description is complete.

What strikes me is how poorly that fits every preferred shortcut, including mine. It will not reduce to a religion, because a group calling itself by the name is not thereby described. It will not reduce to a bloodline either, because Yeshua is part of both statements in 12:17 and 14:12, not an ornament on them. And it does not allow me to erase Israel to make that point; the book is built out of twelve tribes and a temple and Zion and gates bearing tribal names.

Then the part that costs most, and it costs the reading many people bring with them. The buying and selling belongs to the beast, and the beast is judged before Satan is bound. There are a thousand years between that chapter and this one; a mark cannot be carried across them. And Revelation does not say "microchip." It says deceived nations, gathered, advancing, surrounding. Nothing in that sequence concerns payment technology, and noticing this removes much of what has passed for prophecy in my lifetime.

What is left is a description I can test and a people I cannot point to. I can tell you what the saints look like. I cannot tell you where they are — and every time someone has claimed otherwise, the claim has done more damage than silence would have.

On whether the process has begun: it could have. Ezekiel's sequence has preparation before movement and movement before attack, and Revelation's has release before deception

and deception before encirclement. Nothing says the release and the surrounding happen on the same afternoon.

But I have no marker — not one distinctive enough to survive being wrong.

So the chain is finished. It runs from a first-century horizon all the way to a new creation, every link argued rather than assumed, and several of them graded against my own preference. The last thing it needs is a pin pushed into it somewhere near the bottom saying “we are here.”

I do not have that pin. I am not going to make one.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Revelation defines its own term twice, in two different sections, with the same two elements: keeping Yah's commandments, and holding the testimony or faith of Yeshua, under endurance. That definition refuses both institutional Christianity and bare ethnicity, without erasing Israel from a book saturated with it. Revelation's own use of "war" shows that war against God's people is carried out by persecution and coercion rather than by opposing armies, though the word alone cannot decide the nature of the final confrontation. The mark and its restriction on buying and selling belong before the thousand years and cannot be carried across them. The camp is corporate, and "surrounded" keeps its force without becoming a military diagram; the beloved city keeps its Zion resonance, with its geography unresolved. The description of the saints is definable; the people are not locatable. Development between the release and the encirclement is textually possible, but no sufficiently distinctive historical marker exists. The chain is complete from the first-century horizon to the new creation — and the "you are here" marker cannot be placed on it.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** The chain is complete and the marker unplaced. What, then, does this investigation actually establish — and which questions does it leave genuinely open?